

ANNUALS, BIENNIALS, AND BEDDING

Indispensable in pots, containers, and borders, many of these colorful plants flower from early summer to early fall, and some also provide beautiful foliage. Combine them with plants that bloom in winter and spring to brighten up your garden all year.

What are annuals and biennials?

Annuals are plants that grow, bloom, set seed, and die in a single growing season. Biennials complete their life cycle in two seasons: most are sown in late spring or summer and make leafy growth in the first year, then flower, set seed, and die in the next. Bedding plants usually refer to half-hardy or tender annuals that are traditionally used in summer flower schemes. Some plants in this category are technically perennials or even shrubs, but are referred to as annuals because they are used for just one season. Examples include pelargoniums, nemesias, and brachyscome, which are perennials, and marguerites (*Argyranthemum* species), and fuchsias, which are tender shrubs. Plants in this group are also sometimes described as “summer seasonals” and “spring seasonals.”

BELOW Summer harmonies

Combine the shapes and colors of annuals for a balanced display. Begonias, heliotropes, silver-leaved senecio, and zinnias create a vibrant mix.

Growing annuals and biennials

Plants in this category can be grown from seeds, bought as young seedlings known as “plug” plants, or purchased as mature specimens ready to plant.

Sowing seeds is the most cost-effective option if you have a large space or lots of containers to fill; there are many half-hardy or frost-tender types that are very easy to grow in pots or trays on a windowsill or in a greenhouse, including petunias, French marigolds (*Tagetes*), and tobacco plants (*Nicotiana*). The seedlings should be hardened off for a few weeks in spring by placing them outside during the day and bringing them back under cover at night. Then plant them outside in late spring when all danger of frost has passed.

Hardy annuals are easier still, since they can be sown outside in spring where they are to flower. For earlier summer blooms, plants like love-in-a-mist (*Nigella*) and poppies (*Papaver rhoeas*) can be sown in early fall in free-draining soil. Sow your



ABOVE Shades of pink

Create an elegant basket using shades of pink. Dark cherry pink petunias, pale busy Lizzies, starry isotomas, and raspberry-colored diascias combine beautifully.

seeds in straight lines or curves, so that you can distinguish them from weed seedlings when they germinate.

For winter and spring color, most suitable plants, such as violas, are raised from seeds sown in summer. Alternatively, buy young plants in the fall.

Biennials can be grown from seeds or bought as plug plants in the summer before they bloom. Find a quiet corner of the garden to sow your seeds, as they will be there for many months and may be swamped by other plants if sown directly into a summer bed or border.

Ornamental features

Annuals and biennials are available in a wide range of shapes and sizes, from low hummock-forming cultivars of *Ageratum houstonianum* and trailing petunias to the tall spires of foxgloves (*Digitalis purpurea*) and dramatic Scotch thistles (*Onopordum acanthium*) that shoot up to 6ft (1.8m).

Flowers offer a vast choice of colors and forms, including scented types such as heliotropes (*Heliotropium arborescens*), tobacco plants (*Nicotiana* species), and the chocolate-scented *Cosmos atrosanguineus*. Colors extend from the opalescent white of *Omphaloides linifolia* to the vibrant scarlets of pelargoniums, bright orange and yellow Californian poppies (*Eschscholzia californica*), and intense magentas and purples of petunias. For more subtle pastel schemes, opt for plants such as *Anoda cristata*, blue *Silene coeli-rosa*, baby blue eyes (*Nemophila*

